LECTURE 3 : THE LISTENING SKILL

Introduction

Welcome to lecture 3 on skills . In the previous lecture we looked at the nature of communication and how it works. We also looked at some of the barriers that affect the communication process. This week we are going to focus on one of the skills you need in order o communicate effectively: Listening. Before we begin let me ask you a simple question: between speaking and listening which is more important? Well, think about it

Consider this quote:

> ***"God gave us one mouth to do two jobs: eat and speak, but He gave us two ears to do just one job: to listen"***

Think about it, What does the above quote mean mean? Question for your thought.
Well Consider another quote on listening: **'Speech is silver, silence is gold"** What does this mean? That is food for your thought

We can probably say that effective communication is heavily dependent on effective listening, something many of us may not be fully proficient at.

- Why is the process of effective listening so elusive? Think of a time when you have pretended to listen whilst continuing with what you were doing or thinking. Think also
  of a situation where you sought to half listen to another with the intention of tuning in when something of particular importance was said. These are very common occurrences and it is unlikely that you have not experienced them. In fact, most conversations do not take place with the full attention of those taking part.
- However, our ability to selectively listen in this way is not very good and as a result,
  valuable information can be unheard and lost.
- Sometimes, the consequences of bad listening are insignificant, other times they are not. In most of the cases, bad listening creates more problems. Eg Out of the four
  Consider the following scenarios:
  - Drivers fail to listen carefully to directions given by the traffic policeman and roadside people and lose their way.
  - Workers fail to perform their duties effectively as they have not listened to their supervisors.
  - Students are denied credit for assignments, if they have not completed the task as instructed.

- The importance of effective listening cannot be overstated because it is crucial to the success of organizations and individuals alike.
- Studies have shown that listening is the most frequent aspect of workplace communication (Other studies have identified that managers spend 65-90% of their working day listening to someone, with the percentage of time increasing with level of managerial responsibility.
- However, research suggests that misunderstandings are the rule rather than the exception, and that people generally achieve no more than 25-50% accuracy in interpreting the meaning of each other's remarks.
- Becoming fully proficient at listening would therefore seem to have significant influence on workplace communication and related effectiveness.
- Effective listening is a specific skill that can be consciously developed and practiced in various workplace situations, whether a meeting, supervision session, telephone conversation or chance meeting in the corridor.

Lecture outline

- What is Listening?
- Process of Listening.
- Importance of Listening
- Basic Types of Listening
- Barriers to effective listening
- How to Listen Effectively?
- Benefits of Effective Listening

Learning objectives

By the end of this lecture, you should be able to:

- Define listening
- Differentiate listening from hearing
- Discuss the types of listening.
- Demonstrate knowledge of the importance of listening in our lives
- Describe the listening process
- Recognize different types of barriers to active listening
- Be a good listener and apply active listening strategies in different listening situations

LISTENING DEFINED

what is listening?

There are many definitions of listening. The following are some examples.

1. Listening is the active process of **receiving aural stimuli** (De Vito, 1987:26)

2. Listening is a voluntary process that goes beyond simply **reacting to sounds** and includes **understanding, analysing, evaluating, and responding**.
3. Listening is an **active, deliberate, selective** process by which a message is **received, critically interpreted, and acted upon** by a purposeful listener.

Listening Vs Hearing :What is the difference?

Do you think there is a difference between hearing and listening? You are right, there is!

- Hearing is simply the act of perceiving sound by the ear. If you are not hearing-impaired, hearing simply happens.
- Listening, however, is something you consciously choose to do. Listening requires concentration so that your brain processes meaning from words and sentences. Listening leads to learning.
- Listening is different from hearing because hearing is basically a physical activity. Eg, you hear blaring horns and get exposed to noise pollution when you are in a traffic jam. However, listening is a mental activity that involves and uses the brain i.e apart from just hearing it involves selection, organization, interpretation, evaluation and response

Most people tend to be "hard of listening" rather than "hard of hearing."

Importance of Listening in our lives

a) Listening is an essential task for effective communicators. We actually do spend the largest part of our time listening, for instance it has been observed that college students spend up to 50% of their time listening.

b) Listening helps us build and maintain relationship. Part of our ability to build and retain relationships involves our ability to understand and respond empathetically to messages from others.

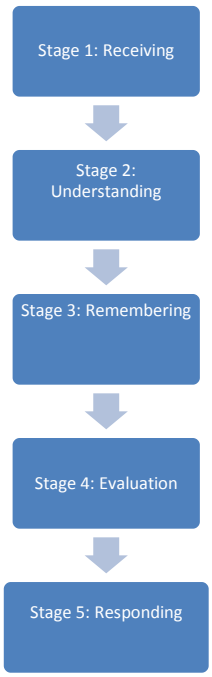
c) Listening can help us determine whether people we are communicating with are honest or deceitful.

d) Listening is an essential skill for success in academics and business world.

e) Listening is directly linked to our ability to remember information.

The process of Listening

Author Joseph DeVito has divided the listening process into five stages: receiving, understanding, remembering, evaluating, and responding. DeVito, J. A. (2000). *The elements of public speaking* (7th ed.). New York, NY: Longman.
As shown below:



Let us now take a look at each of these stages:

1. **Receiving**

   This is a physiological process. Listening i.e. the reception of sounds- at this point we focus on specific sound or a series of sounds

- At this stage, we are still only hearing the message. This stage is represented by the ear because it is the primary tool involved with this stage of the listening process.

How to receive messages more effectively

1) Focus your attention to the speaker or the source. We are focusing on both non-verbal and non verbal. I.e. what is said and what is not said
2) Avoid destruction in the environment- avoid focusing on what you think should have been said by the speaker

3) Maintain your role as a listener, avoid interrupting the speaker until he/she has finished

2. Understanding

- In the understanding stage, we attempt to learn the meaning of the message, which is not always easy.
- It involves Deciding what the message means to you.
- Understanding occurs when you learn what the speaker means. Understanding include the thought that are expressed and the emotional tone that accompany those tones

How to achieve understanding

1) Relate the speaker information to what you already know
2) See the speaker message from the speaker point of view/ avoid judging the message until it has been understood as the speaker intended it
3) Ask for clarifications if it's necessary
4) Ask for additional essays, additional examples if its needed
5) Re-phrase or paraphrase the speaker to check your understanding of the speakers thoughts and the speakers feelings

3. Remembering

Messages that you receive need to be retained for a period of time

How can one ensure more accuracy in remembering?

- Identify the central point / idea and all the supporting details that are given
- Summaries the message in an easier to retain form e.g. the crucial details and summarize in a form that is easier to remember

4. Evaluation

- evaluations of the same message can vary widely from one listener to another.

- It involves making judgment about the message, judging what the message is all about within the context

How to improve

1) Resist evaluation until you fully understand the speakers point of view
2) Give the speaker the benefit of any doubt by asking for clarification or issues you object to
3) Distinguish from opinion interferences or from personal interpretation by the speaker
4) Identify any biases, self interest or prejudices that may emanate from the speaker

5. **Responding**

- sometimes referred to as feedback—your reaction to the message
- It involves giving an overt response to the messages.
- Responding occurs in two ways; the response that you make while the speaker is talking, they are non-verbal. The response that you make when the speaker has stopped talking is verbal (comments, criticisms)
- For example, you are giving positive feedback to your instructor if at the end of class you stay behind to approach the instructor to ask for clarification. The opposite kind of feedback is given by students who gather their belongings and rush out the door as soon as class is over.
- This stage is represented by the lips because we often give feedback in the form of verbal feedback; however, you can just as easily respond nonverbally.

What should we do in order to respond?

1) Be supportive of the speaker
2) During your response state your thoughts and your feelings
3) Think about the proposal your posing about

NB/: To appreciate listening think about its role in communication process. Feedback is an essential part of the communication process

TYPES OF LISTENERS

There are four types of Listeners namely: active listeners, passive listeners, non-listeners and evaluative listeners.

Let us briefly look at those traits that typify these listeners.

Active listeners -active listeners involve themselves actively in the communication process by keenly listening not only to the message but also to the way it has been delivered. They focus on the content as well the manner in which it is delivered. This means that they will take note of the verbal content along with its nonverbal subtexts. They will not hesitate to seek clarifications, ask leading questions, show their approval by nodding head, and summarize to clearly indicate that they fully follow the speaker. In this way, the active listeners are quiet sensitive towards the feelings of others, they understand the mood of the audience. They show empathy and make the audience or the other person cared for. Once the audience get the feeling that they are being cared for, they will devote themselves fully to the communication process. Once there is mutual involvement, there will be hundred per cent success in terms of communication.

Passive listeners

Passive listeners are the opposite of active listeners. They pay attention only to partial message and lack sensitivity to the nuances, inner meanings, nonverbal subtexts involved in communication. They do not make notes, nod their head in approval, maintain eye contact and keep themselves idle. Passive "listening," is actually hearing not listening! Since passive listeners keep their minds closed, communication with them is futile and incomplete.

Non listeners

These type of listeners do not listen at all because they are genuinely disinterested in the subject. They to follow the speaker while they are actually preoccupied with something else. So, they will fake attention, and exhibit such mannerisms as blank stare, impatience and nervousness. Their complete insensitivity and insensible nature makes them incapable of understanding others. In fact, they do not even make an effort to hear what the other person is saying.

Evaluative listeners

Evaluative listeners literally assess the verbal content on the basis of words not paralinguistic or nonverbal cues. Generally, they use logic to understand the content, hence, they distance themselves emotionally from the subject. As a result, they do not show empathy or sensitivity to the speaker. They are mostly prejudiced and

judgmental as they presume the meaning before actually the speaker completes a sentence. Now, you will surprised to know that most of us are evaluative listeners! If we observe ourselves carefully, most of the times we behave like evaluative listeners. Without paying full attention to the content, we always evaluate what somebody is trying to tell us.

TYPES OF LISTENING:

There are two major types of listening, informational and reflective.

1. Active listening – It involves listening with a purpose and comprises:
   a) Listening carefully using all our available senses.
   b) Paraphrasing what we hear both mentally and verbally.
   c) Checking our understanding to ensure accuracy.
   d) Providing feedback positively or negatively.

2. Empathetic listening – It is a form of active listening where we attempt to understand the other person by perceiving their world view as if it is our own. It is putting ourselves in the shoes of another person in order to feel and understand what the person is going through. This kind is very useful in sustaining relationships, counselling process, resolving disputes, as well as dealing with traumatic situations.

3. Critical listening – This is listening that analyses, evaluates, critiques or challenges a speaker's message by evaluating its accuracy, meaningfulness and utility. This goes hand in hand with critical thinking and it involves asking question such as:
   a) Is the speaker's message possible? Is it realistic?
   b) Does the speaker back up his or her claims? Are these claims reliable?
   c) Is the speaker credible or an authority?
   d) Is the message free of contradiction and inconsistencies?

   Critical listening is very useful when we are confronted with persuasive messages such as advertisements, political communications, propaganda and the like.

4. Listening for enjoyment – This type of listening helps us to relax like when we enjoy listening to, for instance, music.
5. Reflective listening

This refers to attentively listening to the speaker's actual words, as well as tone of voice, and observing the body language and emotions displayed. Reflective

listening is particularly an important tool in one- on-one situations. It is not practical in a speaker-audience situation.

6. Passive listening

This means concentrating at a low level and absorbing just enough of the speaker's words to stay involved in a conversation or speech. Such listening is characterized by:

NOTE: No oral communication can be effective without proper listening on the part of the receiver of the message. A tactful manager can positively handle the grapevine or informal channel of communication by 'empathic' listening.

Poor listening may defeat the very purpose of oral communication. It has been found that generally people retain only about one fourth of what they hear after two days. In this way listening becomes the weakest link in oral communication.

Barriers to Effective Listening

- All elements of communication, including listening, may be affected by barriers that can impede the flow of conversation between individuals. It is important for you to know the barriers to listening, so that you are able to deal with them.
- The following are the major types of barriers to listening:

1. **inadequate language proficiency:** sufficient language background is required to fully understand the speaker. Despite one's best efforts to intensely participate in the communication process (a lecture delivered, for instance), inadequate language base will act as a deterrent. Weak language proficiency, lack of technical vocabulary, combined with fear and shyness, will hinder the progress of learning a new subject. Interrupting

Interrupting is something we all do. Sometimes you may be tempted to tune out the speaker because of his or her appearance. eg If a speaker is sloppily dressed and careless about their appearance, you may conclude that what is being said isn't worth listening to. Avoid the temptation and do not let your personal feelings interfere with your listening.

2. Partial listening

Partial listening occurs when people happily indulge themselves in multitasking and allow themselves to be distracted easily. For instance, when talking over the phone during a conversation, many people are habituated to flip through a book, or surf through the internet due to which they fail to pay full attention to the speaker.

Because the mind is involved in too many things, important details are missed in partial listening.

3. **Disinterestedness**

Lack of interest in the subject prevents one to pay complete attention. Students, for instance, may remember a pop song more easily than the name of an author. So, due to disinterestedness in the subject, during a conversation, the listener may focus on other interesting subjects.

4. **Pre-judging the speaker/the speech** The listeners form biased opinions by looking at the speaker's look, dress and mannerism. The bias against the speaker can be formed due to one's own gender and colour preferences. Even the status of the speaker, depending on whether it is high or low, can affect the logical thinking of the listener.

5. **Negativity towards the speaker**

   The major cause of poor listening is due to the listener's emotional, mental and psychological mind-set. If there is any dislike for the speaker and disapproval to his/her ideas, the listener will certainly reconstruct distorted and negative message. When there is negativity, the listener shows animosity, undermines the speaker's capabilities, and keeps disagreeing with the speaker's viewpoints. The listener will even go to the extent of ridiculing, insulting, and humiliating the speaker in public.

6. **Deep-rooted beliefs**
   Sometimes one tends to become close minded due to one's own deep rooted beliefs and convictions. Socio- culturally embedded beliefs and convictions become so strong and firmly rooted in one's minds and act as barriers to new thoughts and fresh ideas. For instance, if one has a deep rooted conviction on caste system based arranged marriage, then the person will not be able to openly listen to a talk on the benefits of inter-caste love marriage. Such deep-rooted beliefs lead to superficial listening and cause disagreement with the speaker's stance and view point.

   Reflect: Make an honest estimate of your barriers to active listening and take constant efforts to overcome them. In the next and the final lecture of this module, I will throw light on active listening techniques and the benefits of effective listening.
   - save time, energy, and other resources
   - increase chances for advancement and success

ACTIVE LISTENING TECHNIQUES

Take notes

Whether you are attending a lecture in the classroom or a speech in an auditorium or you are interviewing someone, it is important to keep a note book for taking notes. Taking notes helps in concentrating. It keeps you alert and makes you focused on the message. It helps you to reflect on the lecture and reconstruct important parts of it. You should also take notes while you are on telephone conversation. You will miss important details (such as the time, venue of an appointment) if you do not take notes while talking to someone on phone.

Do not interrupt the speaker

Interrupting not only affects the speaker's flow of thought but also showcases one's rude and uncultured self.

Avoid multitasking

Once you have decided to listen to something, give yourself wholeheartedly to the task. Make your mind, body, and soul engaged completely in the listening activity. Avoid reading newspaper, while checking messages on your mobile, and responding to e-mails on

Ask questions

You should not sit idly even when the session is open for questions from the audience. Be prepared for this moment, especially while taking notes itself, identify questions to be asked at the end of the speech. Ask questions without any hesitation. Only by asking questions and seeking clarifications, you will gain conceptual clarity. At the same time, a good speaker welcomes questions since it gives an opportunity to cover up some significantly missed points in the talk. Further, your thought-provoking questions may spur the speaker to delve deep into his/her research area. Your questions will make the speaker connected with you and can sometimes help in developing a wonderful relationship for future.

Note: When you ask questions, do not ask closed questions such as the ones that need only "yes" or "no" for answers. Ask open questions that will make the speaker say more about the subject. For instance, do not ask: "Has this been going on for twenty years?" Ask: "How long has this been going on?" Continue further with "Why so?", "Can you explain?", "Please elaborate", "How did you feel about the whole experience", and so on.

Seek clarification

When you do not follow the main drift of the talk, seek clarification. There is a difference between asking question and seeking clarification. Having understood the subject, you ask questions. But when you seek clarification, you admit that the idea is complex and you are not able to understand. And thus, you request the speaker to say more on the subject from a different angle. Good speakers will approach the same issue through a different perspective and make it interesting for you and easy to grasp the subject.

Show empathy

Instead of ridiculing the speaker for silly mistakes, show care and empathy. Offer to help the speaker. I remember a talk in a conference in which an eminent speaker's transparencies flew away from the overhead projector. My spontaneous support to the speaker in quickly getting the transparencies rearranged helped me develop a lasting relationship with the speaker.

Avoid positive bias/influence

In this information age, you are surrounded by media and constantly flooded with information. Nonetheless, you should be able to evaluate the accuracy, correctness and validity of a message, however positive it might sound at the outset. To illustrate this, I want you to read and evaluate the following message carefully:

choose strategic seating: posture can affect listening; therefore choose a physical location that is conducive, comfortable and practical.

Summary :

• Effective communication is heavily dependent on effective listening; however most conversations do not take place with the full attention of those taking part.

• Effective listening is a specific skill that can be consciously developed and practiced. It is an active psychological process which enables us to attach meaning to all the information we receive.

• Developing effective listening skills involves two specific steps: dealing with *barriers* that prevent you listening; and developing and using listening *behaviours*.

• There are various *barriers* to listening, including jumping to conclusions; hearing what we want to hear; rehearsing our response and being inattentive.

• *Active listening skills* include using attending skills (e.g. maintaining an open posture, comfortable eye contact, leaning forward); delaying evaluation; maintaining attention; reflecting back or paraphrasing; giving feedback; listening for feelings; asking appropriate questions etc.